DIPLOMA PROGRAMME PRACTICE / HL / SET B

Psychology / Paper 2

Worked mark scheme · 90 minutes · 35 marks

Answer all five questions. For Section A draw on the specified practical you conducted in class. For Section B, use the unseen study in this booklet.

Judge the whole response against the question-specific markband. Award zero for no creditworthy material. The worked answers illustrate one route; credit other scientifically defensible answers. Class-practical examples are illustrative.

SECTION A

Your class practical

QUESTION 1 / 4 MARKS

Describe the aim and procedure of the survey or questionnaire you used in your human relationships class practical.

Illustrative response. Suppose a class asked whether adult students felt able to disagree in groups of different sizes. Fourteen volunteers completed an anonymous questionnaire referring to their last small-group and whole-class discussions. Both items used the same five response categories with labelled endpoints. The class compared each respondent's two ratings and summarised a voluntary open comment. Instructions specified the time period and that the teacher would receive only group summaries.

Marking a student's own practical. The student's own aim, sample, item format, administration and record may differ. Credit an accurate connected account of the actual survey. Merely listing advantages of questionnaires does not describe how the student used one.

Markband. 1–2: some relevant method detail with gaps or imprecise terms. 3–4: accurate and specific methodological knowledge describes how the actual practical was conducted.

QUESTION 2 / 4 MARKS

Explain one way in which bias could have affected the findings of your class questionnaire.

Illustrative response. A learner who fears appearing disloyal may report being comfortable disagreeing even when uncomfortable. If whole-class disagreement feels particularly visible, this pressure may distort that item more than the small-group item, narrowing the observed difference. Anonymous administration reduces the chance of identification but cannot guarantee that participants stop managing how they appear.

Marking a student's own practical. Accept sampling, wording, order or response bias if the student locates it in their actual questionnaire and explains its likely consequence. Small samples increase uncertainty; size alone does not establish a systematic direction of bias.

Markband. 1–2: a relevant concept with a limited link to the practical. 3–4: the concept is clearly explained through specific choices or findings in the actual practical.

QUESTION 3 / 6 MARKS

Compare and contrast the methodology of the survey used in your practical with a semi-structured interview investigating the same topic.

Illustrative response. Both ask people for accounts and both can be affected by social desirability. A survey can present the same group-size comparison privately and in the same order to every respondent. An interview could use the same core prompts but follow an unexpected distinction, such as disagreeing with a friend versus a tutor. This may reveal why respondents gave identical ratings for quite different experiences.

Developing the comparison. An interviewer can clarify what “disagree” means but their reactions may shape what is disclosed. An anonymous questionnaire can cover more people within class time, at the cost of losing an opportunity to probe. Open survey items and coded interview responses are both possible. Effective answers compare the methods point by point and connect at least one consequence to the class practical.

Markband. 1–2: brief or partly inaccurate comparisons. 3–4: similarities and differences receive uneven or partial explanation. 5–6: both are developed in a direct comparison using accurate research terminology.

QUESTION 4 / 6 MARKS

Design an observation to investigate the same topic as your class questionnaire.

Illustrative design. For the illustrative questionnaire, obtain consent from adults for an overt observation of routine group discussions. Observe comparable discussion periods, rotate which size group is observed first and state what counts as a disagreement, such as an explicitly different proposal. Record dissenting turns and the number of opportunities to speak, using anonymous codes. Do not identify named speakers in the report.

From record to finding. Two trained observers independently code a shared segment and examine discrepancies before using the agreed definitions. Compare rates per opportunity instead of raw counts from groups of different sizes. This observation can address expressed disagreement but cannot directly observe how safe a silent participant feels. Accept another feasible observational design investigating the student's own topic.

Markband. 1–2: a method is named but its operation is unclear. 3–4: a workable outline lacks precision or connection to the aim. 5–6: a clear, detailed design uses the specified method appropriately to investigate the same topic.

SECTION B

Evaluation of an unseen study

QUESTION 5 / 15 MARKS

Researchers explored how new students at two colleges learned when it was acceptable to interrupt a class discussion. College X was studied in its first teaching week; College Y was studied after six weeks. At each college a tutor nominated eight newcomers described as “settling in well”. One local moderator held a recorded focus group. At X the discussion was transcribed in the language used; at Y it was translated before coding.

Two analysts using a common codebook agreed on 85% of a subset of coding decisions. Twelve of 20 coded references at X and six of 24 at Y concerned fear of interrupting. One participant supplied seven of the 12 references at X. A report described this as a six-week decline in fear as students adapted. An identifiable quotation from a small course was proposed for the college newsletter. These materials are constructed.

Discuss the study with reference to two or more of these concepts: change, perspective, measurement and responsibility.

Worked analysis. The two groups were not followed over time. College, language, moderator and time since entry changed together. Different frequencies of references are compatible with adaptation but do not show a decline within any student. Tutor nominations may omit students who felt least able to interrupt, and group discussion may privilege participants prepared to speak.

Linking concepts. Twelve of 20 references versus six of 24 compares talk, not the proportion of students who were fearful. One participant generated most references at X. A shared codebook and a second analyst improve consistency; 85% agreement cannot establish that the translated term had the same meaning in both settings. Participants' explanations of a respectful pause might differ from an analyst's label of fear. Reviewing interpretations with bilingual contributors could uncover that difference.

Reasoned appraisal. Re-interview the same volunteers over time in each college, retain contrasting cases and examine how speaking opportunities were distributed. Permission to record a focus group does not automatically cover an identifiable public quotation. Discuss specific consent or paraphrasing and the limits of confidentiality among group members. The study can illuminate possible interpretations of classroom norms; stronger evidence is needed for the claimed change.

Markband. 1–3: isolated comments or a minimal connection to the study. 4–6: relevant concepts are described with limited application. 7–9: study details support some analysis but links between concepts and methodological consequences are uneven. 10–12: developed, balanced evaluation relates at least two concepts to particular decisions and findings. 13–15: well-integrated concepts, accurate terminology and evidence produce a sustained critical evaluation and a justified judgement about this study.